



◀ Tarot comes to America

The first tarot style to gain major popularity in North America was the Egyptian deck designed by French occultists René Falconner and Maurice Otto Wegener in 1890, based on ideas by Jean-Baptiste Pitois.

Kabbalistic tarot

As fascination with the occult grew in the 19th century, people increasingly used the tarot deck for divination rather than for games. Each card had a set meaning, which altered if that card was inverted when laid out.

One of the leading figures of tarot divination was Eliphas Lévi (see p.213), a French bohemian and socialist who in the 1860s wrote a series of books that made him a household name in the world of magic. Lévi believed that magic was the scientific basis of man's divinity. He observed an apparent link between tarot and the mystical tradition of Kabbalah (see pp.136–139), noting that the 22 trump cards of tarot match the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet. Lévi drew further links, and argued that the tarot could act as a road map through the Kabbalah Tree of Life, leading to enlightenment and heaven. It was Lévi's work that made tarot such a popular tool for divination.

In 1870, French occultist Jean-Baptiste Pitois's book *The History and Practice of Magic* explained the symbols of tarot as originating in initiation tests for Magi to reach the secret chambers under the Great Pyramid of Giza. Significantly, Pitois also described the tarot deck as dividing into two arcana (groups).

The Arcana

The Major Arcana (greater secrets) comprise the 22 trump cards, such as The Magician, The Star, and The Hanged Man; they do not belong to any suit, but carry specific significance. The Minor Arcana (lesser secrets) comprise the 56 suit cards, divided into four suits of 14 each. The first 78-card deck design based on Pitois's system is also known as the Tarot de Marseilles, as the game of tarot persisted in France long after it had died out in Italy.

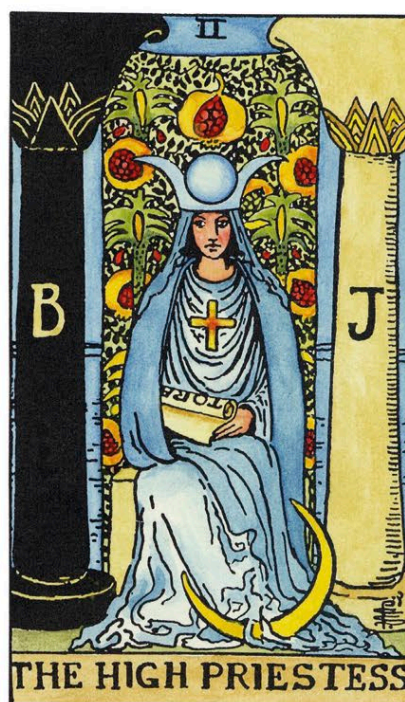
In 1889, Swiss occultist Oswald Wirth designed a 22-card trump-only deck for divination based on kabbalistic symbols. Each trump card has its own links, for example: The Magician bridges the gap between the earth and heaven; The High Priestess, originally called La Papesse, was thought to refer to the female pope, Pope Joan. Since then many other packs have been designed for fortune-telling, although the tarot deck itself is still used for card games in France and Italy.



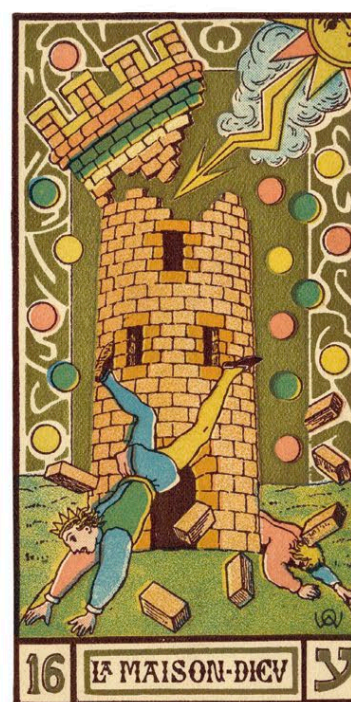
The Magician in this design is from the first English tarot deck of 1910.



The Devil here is a 19th-century French card influenced by Lévi.



The High Priestess design here is from the English 1910 Rider-Waite deck.



This Tower is a 1926 design by Wirth with kabbalistic symbols.